

Q This is your first trip to India. So far, how has the interaction been with the community here? Anything unique that struck you?

GR: A few days back, we were in front of roughly 300 people in Chennai and they were really looking forward to talking with us. We got bombarded with questions; it was a very lively audience.

Whenever I speak to the community here, I see the same enthusiasm as I see elsewhere in the world. I can see the same kind of aspirations here as I see anywhere else and that's what keeps me going. That's what moved me to be part of Open Source India too. I am seeing that kind of magic happening over here too.

Q Would you call this trip and your engagement at Open Source India as successful? What would be the parameters to measure the success?

GR: Yes, it has been a very successful event because I managed to meet a lot of people. It was about meeting the right seeds within the right people. I also met the developers and was able to understand what their aspirations and problems are. So I am taking away important lessons from this experience, like how they could support the community and that hard work is important. And of course, what counts is not the visit to the country, but the follow ups with local branches, the vendors, friends and corporate organisations.

Q Please elaborate on Microsoft's involvement with open source. What has Microsoft's open source strategy been?

GR: First, you have to recognise that Microsoft is a huge organisation. There are various businesses (divisions) at Microsoft which look at open source differently. Yes, Microsoft surely wants to be as 'open' as we can possibly get. Openness is a crucial part of the future IT strategies of every company out there.

In fact, I am still to be in a meeting (at Microsoft) where open source is being discussed as an issue. We see it as an opportunity (and not a challenge). Even within Microsoft, we feel that open source is one of the key ways in which the software fabric works.

Q Is your open source association restricted to the Azure platform only?

GR: No, it goes way beyond Azure. However, it is surely an important example of the way in which we have been engaging with the open source community since a long time.

Now, when a lot of developers work on the Web, they are mostly interested in the server side; this is why most of them are talking about Azure and about our servers.

Q On the mobile front, two popular platforms are the iOS for the iPhone and Android OS. While the former is totally closed, the other is mostly open. And then comes your platform, which is basically a closed platform with some 'branch cuts' for the open source community. In



Gianugo Rabellino with Mandar Naik, director, Platform Strategy, Microsoft, India

such a scenario, what would be your message to the open source community with respect to going open?

GR: Well, what I would like them (mobile developers) to know is that we are welcoming them with open arms. And, we are putting in a lot of effort to help them build new exciting mobile applications for Windows phones.

Let me give you a few examples—I recently talked about PhoneGap which allows you to develop software for all popular mobile platforms including iPhone, Google Android, BlackBerry, Symbian and Palm. If you are a developer, you just want to build a single solution that can run on different devices. PhoneGap solves that problem.

Plus, we also want developers to be aware of the link between PhoneGap and the Windows framework, and we accomplish this by sharing guidelines, white papers and tutorials for iOS, Android and Symbian developers.

We recently came up with an API mapping guide, which is basically a tool that will allow iOS or Android developers access to the nitty-gritty of not only developing apps easily for the Windows 7 framework, but also porting their existing iOS or Android apps to the Windows framework.

Q In the Android or the Google ecosystem, a competitive spirit is encouraged with initiatives like motivating developers to go open whenever they want. Does Microsoft practice anything like this?

GR: Not that I know of, but I admit it's a great idea.

However, I am aware of some initiatives that are about engaging with developers and motivating them to write apps for the Windows platform. One of these, which I would really like to mention, is the Imagine Cup.

Through this competition we target the students community and our message to them is: "You are the ones who probably have the gears to change the world, to address the big social issues, to change the big picture. Go wild. You are free to think of anything that uses our technology or somebody else's technology. Just share the idea with us; it will be judged by your peers, experts, technologists, etc, and there will be winners for different challenges."

I think it's an exciting event. Last year, I was involved as one of the members of the jury of the Imagine Cup,